

■ 20,000 TONS The amount of bombs dropped on North Vietnam during the bombing.



On target

A US Air Force Boeing B-52 Stratofortress drops its bombs over North Vietnam during the Linebacker II offensive. Some B-52s were brought down by surface-to-air missiles.

Political firestorm

In America, where pundits dubbed the operation the Christmas Bombing, a firestorm of political protest ensued. Newspaper editorials uniformly rejected the bombing. Marches and protests took place in many cities despite the winter cold. There were rumors of Air Force pilots refusing orders—and actual instances of the radio spies of the Teaball (radio interception) unit halting work. Alexander Haig said later that Nixon gave up the Christmas Bombing because his cabinet deserted him and there were threats of impeachment. The bombing was not sustainable politically any more than it was militarily. Admiral Moorer told his colleagues on the Joint Chiefs of Staff that he had tried to get Nixon to continue the bombing until the North Vietnamese signed an agreement, not simply agreed to reopen talks, but that he had failed in that endeavor.